Indian contact with Mauritius began as early as the 17th century when the Dutch brought convicts and slaves from Indian settlements.[5] The 18th century saw more contact as Mauritius came under the French rule, when Indians from Pondicherry were brought in as slaves, workers, craftsmen, companions and servants to the island, known then as the Isle of France, which served as a strategic trading post for the French in the Indian Ocean. There were Indian women as well, as slaves and single migrants who could become property owners through liaisons with the colonists. In one remarkable case, Marie Rozette, a slave of Indian origin, was freed, secured a large fortune through moneylending and trading and owned property and twelve slaves by 1790, making her one of the richest women on the island.

British rule in Mauritius commenced in 1810 during the Napoleonic Wars, at a time when slavery was declining. From 1815, Indian convicts were brought in to work on road and bridge projects. In 1825, Mauritius received sugar tariff parity on the output from the West Indies entering Britain, setting the stage for it to become a major sugar exporter. By 1830, there were around 70,000 slaves on the island, of which around 3000 were Indians. With the formal abolition of slavery in British colonies in 1833–34, the decision to import indentured labour for the sugar plantations was taken by estate-owners, some of whom were Indians. In the initial years, the recruitment methods were considerably criticized. Emigration was prohibited in 1839, only to resume in 1842 on a greater scale and under new controls. *Sirdar*s emerged as key intermediaries in the recruitment process by bringing labour from among their own kin and villages.

Between 1834 and 1900, around half a million Indians were brought to Mauritius as indentured labour, the highest for any colony, of whom a third returned to India. After the expiry of their indenture contracts, many of them moved away from the estates into the ‘Indian’ villages in Mauritius. The descendants of these indentured migrants still live on the island and now comprise two-thirds of the million-strong population, making it the most ‘Indian’ country outside South Asia. Unsurprisingly, the Indo-Mauritians have controlled political power after Independence from the British in 1968. They witnessed decent economic prosperity in the 20th